

SOUTHERN LATITUDES

THE STARS

The distinctive figures of Orion and Taurus are high in the northeast, with Gemini and Auriga closer to the horizon. Perseus lies low in the north, while the Square of Pegasus sets in the northwest, followed by Pisces. Fomalhaut (see p.253) in Piscis Austrinus is in the southwest.

Eridanus, the River, meanders southwestward from the foot of Orion, ending at the bright star Achernar. Brighter Canopus is high in the southeast in Carina. The Large and Small Magellanic Clouds (see p.310 and p.311) lie high in the south, on either side of the celestial meridian. In the east, Betelgeuse in Orion, Procyon in

Canis Minor, and Sirius in Canis Major form a large triangle, which is a sign of the approaching southern summer.

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

December and January evenings are the best time for southern observers to see the Pleiades (see p.291) and Hyades (see p.290), two large and prominent open star clusters north of the equator in Taurus. The Large Magellanic Cloud, containing the Tarantula Nebula, NGC 2070, is high in the southeast, but it is better seen in January. Overall, the southern evening sky is bereft of prominent deep-sky objects near the celestial meridian this month.



THE LARGE MAGELLANIC CLOUD

The LMC (bottom) lies deep in the southern sky between the bright stars Canopus (left) and Achernar (top right). The small pink patch on the LMC is the Tarantula Nebula.

POSITIONS OF THE PLANETS

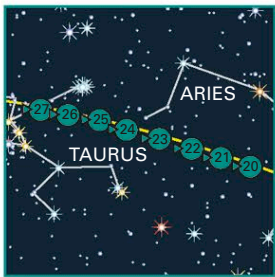
This chart shows the positions of the planets in December from 2020 to 2027. The planets are represented by colored dots, while the number inside each dot denotes the year. For all planets apart from Mercury, the dot indicates the planet's position on December 15. Mercury is shown only when it is at greatest elongation (see p.68)—for the specific date, refer to the table, left.

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|---------|---------|--------|---------|
| Mercury | Mars | Saturn | Neptune |
| Venus | Jupiter | Uranus | |

EXAMPLES

- 20 Jupiter's position on December 15, 2020
- 23 Jupiter's position on December 15, 2023. The arrow indicates the planet is in retrograde motion (see p.68).

URANUS



NEPTUNE

